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Happy anniversary, Koha

LIBRARY COLUMN

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George Williams Associated Press

Last year I wrote a column about the Latah County Library District's transition to our new library software, Koha, and how this was a good thing for library users. At that time I emphasized library users would find the new catalog easier to use, library staff would find it easier to check materials in and out, and the cost to the library district for using Koha would be less than what we were paying to stay with our old system. So, I thought I'd write about my favorite things that have changed with our new system in the last year.

The change I hear the most about from library users is that it is easier to place holds using the Koha catalog. In our old system, placing a request was cumbersome. In Koha, placing a hold is easier - plus you have the ability to post-date holds as well as to suspend holds. Let's say, for example, that it's April 27 and you want to place a hold on "Fear and Loathing in Las Vegas," but you know that you'll be out of town until May 15. You can go ahead and place the request immediately but "post-date" it by setting the request date to May 15. This way the item won't be on hold for you until you get back to town. Likewise, if you already have items on hold and you have to leave town suddenly, you can suspend those holds until you get back. This way the hold won't come to you until you're back and won't lose your place in line for the request if it comes when you're gone.

I also appreciate how much easier it is to search our new catalog. In the past if you searched for the Stephen King book "It," for example, no matter how hard you tried, "It" was at least the 10th result. In our new catalog, "It" is at the top of the list. Instead of handling searches like older library catalogs, Koha handles searches in much the same way that Google handles an internet search - and that's what most people expect when they're searching a library catalog on the Internet.

My favorite change is that we no longer have to shut down our catalog for extended periods of time when we have a software upgrade or patch. Most people probably haven't noticed this change but longtime library users may remember that an upgrade used to mean that our catalog was offline for three

days. Even a simple patch required at least one day of downtime. With our new system, all of our system maintenance has taken place between Saturday night and Sunday morning. In the last year, we had two patches, an upgrade and we moved our data from one server to another. The effect of these changes on library service was negligible. Most people - including library staff members - don't even realize when upgrades have taken place because the process is so unobtrusive.

Koha is a free and open source system and this is one of its best features. Not only does this mean it is less expensive, but also we can customize the system ourselves. Instead of recommending a change to a software company and then hoping in three or four years they might add the change to their software, we can now hire someone who knows how to write computer code to make the change we want. And if we want to make relatively minor changes, we can do many of these ourselves.

So, if you haven't tried our catalog in the last year, be sure to check it out at www.latahlibrary.org - just click on the link that reads Catalog. Happy anniversary, Koha.

George Williams is Access Services manager of the Latah County Library District.

